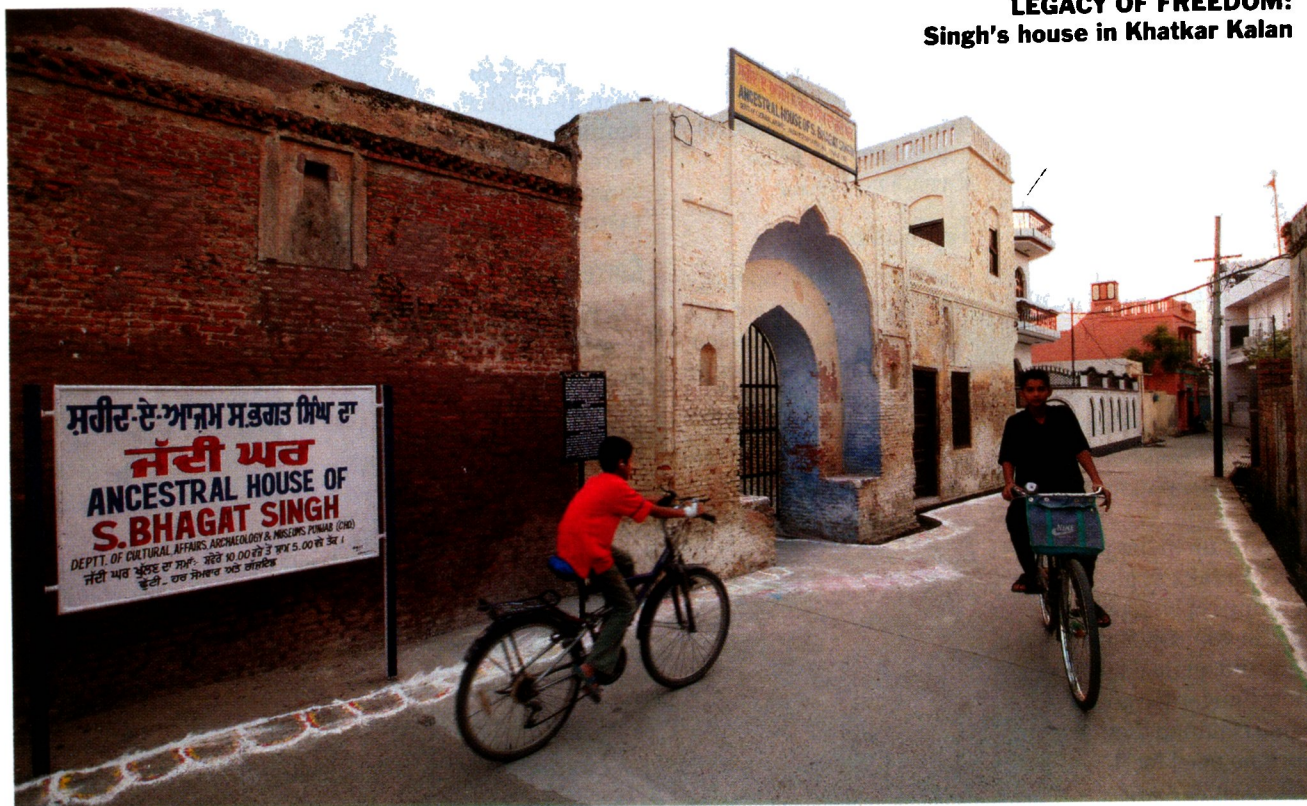


LEGACY OF FREEDOM: Singh's house in Khatkar Kalan



Belated Tribute to a Martyr

After years of neglect, the centenary year of Bhagat Singh's birth gives his village a reason to rejoice

■ By Ramesh Vinayak

Red-stone archway, concrete streets lit with solar lamps and a tastefully-landscaped park with a coloured fountain—this is no heritage resort but a humble village, with a history. Seventy-six years after laying down his life for the country, a son of this soil has become the harbinger of its prosperity. Khatkar Kalan, a village on the Chandigarh-Jalandhar highway in Punjab's Doaba region, today typifies development not because of affluent NRIs but because it is the birth place of Shaheed Bhagat Singh and 2007 happens to be the hundredth year of his birth. Both the Centre and the state Government have chipped in to spruce up his native village to mark the centenary celebrations.

While the Centre has sanctioned a grant of Rs 1 crore for the maintenance of Singh's 150-year-old ancestral house and beautification of the surrounding area, the state Government has given an equal amount for other development works in the village. A library has been built at the village square and also a 200-kW solar power plant to meet the growing demands of energy in the village. Even though Khatkar Kalan boasts of four government-run schools, Chief Minister Parkash Singh Badal recently laid the foundation stone for another Adarsh School to provide quality education to the poor and the needy. To attract tourists, a Rs 52-lakh fast food



complex is under construction near Shaheed Bhagat Singh Museum.

For years this village had been a venue for politicians to pay lip service to the memory of the martyrs. A slew of promises were announced every year on March 23—the day Singh and his companions Sukhdev and Rajguru were hanged by the British rulers in 1931. A commemorative ritual, these promises, involving a substantial

and regular state funding, were never fulfilled. Things started changing in 2003 with the visit of the then President A.P.J. Abdul Kalam, who took a personal interest in promoting this neglected village as a symbol of freedom struggle.

But not everybody is happy with this spit and polish of just the outer façade. Village sarpanch Kewal Singh rues that the development has bypassed the needs of the locals. "Instead of being active participants, we are only at the receiving end of these lofty schemes," he adds, pointing out that the village is yet to get a 100-bed hospital and a sports stadium, the long-promised projects for which foundation stones were laid years ago. Even the martyr's kin are not too enamoured with this "imposed model" of development. "Instead of imbuing the youth with Bhagat Singh's ideology, the emphasis is on creating infrastructure," laments Jagmohan Singh, Bhagat Singh's nephew. But a beginning has been made and that should be reason enough to celebrate.